

The mediation of tourism experiences through storytelling in social media: How DMOs can utilise consumer storytelling in their brand narratives

Niels Frederik Lund
University of Surrey, UK
Nielsfrederik.lund@surrey.ac.uk

Abstract

People are increasingly connecting in online social networks where they share content and experiences and consequently influence each other's perceptions and buying behaviour. This poses a distinct challenge for the tourism sector and destination management organisations in particular, as they are responsible for branding and marketing a destination. This thesis conceptualise social media as fluid performative spaces of storytelling. The concepts performance, performativity, mobility and power form a theoretical framework that facilitates an analysis of the politicised storytelling mechanisms in online social networks. It is suggested that DMOs surrender control of the brand and instead concentrate on collaborating with social media storytellers. This may lead to a strengthening of destination narratives.

1 Problem definition

Consumers are increasingly connecting in social media. For instance, twenty-seven percent of total U.S. internet time is spent on social networking sites and forty-six percent of online adults use social media to communicate with friends (Experian, 2013; White Pages, 2012). The sharing of personal stories in social media influence behaviour; what people do; where they go and what they purchase (Adams, 2012). Consequently, people's comments, reviews and mediated tourism experiences also influence travel behaviour. In other words, people are actively involved in co-constructing narratives about tourism destinations through their shared tourism experiences (Amersdorffer, Bauhuber and Oellrich, 2012). Studies show ninety-three percent of travellers are influenced by reviews in their travel planning and eighty percent of people about to make a travel purchase will ask members of their social network for a recommendation first (Digital Tourism Think Tank, 2013). Thus, social networks are seen as a trustworthy source (Lange-Faria and Elliot, 2012).

This situation poses a distinct challenge for destination management organisations (DMOs) responsible for developing the tourism sector long-term by formulating marketing and branding strategies (Morrison, 2013). However, they have to realise that brands are the product of people's conversations in social networks, both offline and online, rather than marketing strategies. Social media is thus facilitating a power shift towards the consumer and a democratisation of brand construction (Xiang and Gretzel, 2010; Månsson, 2011; Lo, McKercher, Lo, Cheung and Law, 2011; Amersdorffer, Bauhuber and Oellrich, 2012). Hence, DMOs must find ways to connect with people in social media and join their conversations in order to influence perceptions of their destination. However, they face a difficult task as people find companies intrusive and inauthentic (Fournier and Avery, 2011). Thus, this thesis believes that DMOs need to turn their attention to storytelling in order to create a bond with consumers in social media.

Stories are important because human nature is essentially story-based (Schank, 1990). Thus, "Information is indexed, stored and retrieved in the form of stories" (Woodside, 2010, p. 532). Ultimately, people are "*homo narrans*" where telling stories are part of

human nature (Fisher, 1984, p. 6). Furthermore, they make sense of their lives and their role in society via stories (Escalas, 1997). According to McCabe and Foster (2006), tourism experiences are essentially 'stories' about events, places and people. Hence, great stories can become great experiences. As Chronis (2012) states, it is stories that transform otherwise indifferent spaces into attractive tourist destinations. Thus, he suggests that tourism marketers should focus on the narrative staging of tourism places, as the narrative structure is the core organising principle in the presentation of tourism venues (Chronis, 2012).

Storytelling also permeates social media. People are connected on multiple digital platforms where they mediate their experiences (Baker, 2012). Hence, they can share their stories to a large number of people whom they may influence. As Bryon (2012, p. 27) posits, "Due to changing tourist desires, the rise of the experience economy and technological innovations, the demand for stories has dramatically increased over the last few years". Therefore, due to higher expectation with regard to service as well as information overload, people are difficult to please. Without a unique and interesting story, there is nothing distinctive about a destination and its brand (Bierman, 2010). Hence, virtual spaces also need to be narratively staged. DMOs should thus aim to share appealing stories that will lead to exciting experiences, which raise expectations about a certain destination.

DMOs therefore have to find ways to cooperate with social media storytellers and utilise them as brand advocates who may be aligned with the desired brand narrative. A possible approach would be to employ 'open source branding', a method conceptualised by Fournier and Avery (2011, p. 193). It can empower the consumers and facilitate a co-construction of the brand, which aligns the storytelling of consumers with the preferred narratives of DMOs. Furthermore, the DMOs have to present themselves as just another person within the social networks in order to create emotional bonds that enables the promotion of the brand (Fournier and Avery, 2011). Hence, this thesis aims to investigate the opportunities for DMOs to cooperate with storytellers in social media spaces in order to promote the destination narrative. The aim is reached by observing the performances of storytelling in mediating personal tourism experiences via social media. The DMOs' practices and strategies with regard to social media are also identified.

2 Literature review

The literature on DMOs and social media can be divided into two streams. One stream explores the opportunities for utilising social media for market research and marketing (Munar, 2012; Tussydiah and Fesenmeier, 2008; Callarisa, García, Cardiff and Roshchina, 2012; Parra-Lopes, Bulchand-Gidumal, Gutiérrez-Taño, and Díaz-Armas, 2011; Schmallegger and Carson, 2008; Lange-Faria and Elliot, 2012). Another stream examines to what degree social media and electronic word-of-mouth (eWOM) can have an impact on destination image and choice (Ghazali and Cai, 2013; Lin and Huang, 2006; Schmallegger, Carson and Jacobsen, 2010; Volo, 2010; Gretzel, 2006; Gretzel & Yoo, 2008; White, 2010; Månsson, 2011; Lo, McKercher, Lo, Cheung and Law, 2011; Amersdorffer, Bauhuber and Oellrich, 2012; Jacobsen and Munar, 2012).

The same picture emerges when reviewing the over-all research on tourism and social media. As Leung, Law, Hoof and Buhalis (2013) point out, literature on tourism

social media can broadly be divided into consumer centric studies, which concentrates on the research phase of travellers' planning process and on the other hand, supplier related studies, which concentrates on promotion, management and research functions. Thus, tourism research on social media has thus far been approached from a business administration perspective and is influenced by agendas developed by management and marketing theory (Munar, Guimothy and Cai, 2013).

Further enquiry from a social science perspective is therefore desirable in social media tourism research. Nevertheless, apart from the anthology by Munar et al. (2013) little research has been done from that perspective. However, this thesis moves branding into the sphere of social sciences as it sees brands as a result of improvised performances of storytelling in social circles. As marketing scholars (Fournier and Avery, 2011; Singh and Sonnenburg, 2012) suggest, consumers are constructing the brand through their performances in social media; they are in some ways the actual marketers as they are converging with the producers (and other stakeholders) in the creation of content. Hence, brands are not demarcated coherent entities. Rather they are formed by a plethora of narratives and are products of social conversations; they change with each story (Singh and Sonnenburg, 2012). Hence, brands are multiple and fluid and they are part of individual's bricolages of self-representation in social media. Furthermore, they present multiple realities and stories and they are transformed with time and in different contexts. Hence, social sciences and management theories are fused together. Brands may initially be the products of marketing and promotion; but they are reconstructed by socially and culturally driven performances, performativities, and mobilities. They are a product of the social.

This research will therefore fill a considerable gap in existing literature. It is applying social sciences in tourism social media research where it conceptualises social media spaces as fluid, performative spaces of storytelling in which consumers and producers are co-constructing brand narratives. Moreover, it looks at how stories are mobilised by individual performances, socialities and power. Most importantly, the thesis is studying the mediation of tourism experiences through storytelling in social media in order to investigate the potential of collaborating with these storytellers to strengthen the brand narratives. Furthermore, it will consider strategies for strengthening the collaboration. While there has been a cataloguing of social media strategies of DMOs (Munar, 2012), no tourism research have thus far attempted to explicitly examine the strategies of collaboration. Thus, this PhD makes a valuable contribution to existing research.

3 Conceptual development

The conceptual development draws on four concepts, which are performances, performativity, mobility and power in order to describe the politics and social mechanisms of storytelling within social media. Together these concepts form a theoretical framework, which conceptualises social media as fluid spaces of storytelling where performances, storytelling, mobility and performativity are identified as power technologies that shape 'regimes of truths' (Foucault, 1977). In the following paragraph, there is a short explanation of the four concepts' role with regard to social media storytelling. It is worth noting that in this context, the term 'social media' represents the online social networks that are the main pursuit of most social media platforms.

First, social media are spaces where members stage performances and conduct impression management (Grasmuck, Martin & Zhao, 2009; Krämer & Winter, 2008). Tourism destinations give them a stage to act on where they can perform a desirable self. Thus, their identities, roles and performances play an important role in the depiction of the destination. For instance, if they present an image on social media where they are engaged in pleasurable activities, the audience may perceive the destination as an attractive place. Second, social media can be regarded as performative spaces where embodied performances construct space and realities (Nash, 2000; Butler, 1993). Hence, when tourists mediate their experiences, they present their interpretation of the destination and thus their reality. However, social media are also frameworks of performativity, as the individual is performed through repetition of discursively given norms, categories and templates (Van House, 2011; Cover, 2012). Therefore, the social media platforms have an impact on the kind of stories that tourists perform. Third, social media and the mobile devices that make them accessible are seen as new mobility systems, as they facilitate physical and communicative mobility (Elliott & Urry, 2011). Mobility can also be seen as a resource that facilitates the sharing of stories. Furthermore, it produces social relations and power (Cresswell, 2010). Therefore, mobility is a key concept as it enables stories to flow across social media platforms, which enables social networking and influence perceptions. Furthermore, social media provides a fluid mooring that delivers a momentary sense of belonging (a quick fix) while representing liquid identities in continued transformation. It illustrates the paradox of peoples' urge for mobility and their need to re-embed. Fourth, social media and mobile devices are conceptualised as 'technologies of power' that can be used as tools in the execution of power (Foucault, 1977). They enable the sharing of mediated tourism experiences, which draws power to storytellers. Social media storytellers can thus share alternative versions of the 'truth' that circulate and influence discourses and consequently brand narratives.

The theoretical framework facilitates an analysis of social media where clusters of storytelling agents are fighting to influence discourses and brand narratives as part of their quest for power, mobility and social recognition, often at the expense of others. DMOs thus face a complex mediated world where alternative versions of the 'truth' are shared and circulated. They have to manoeuvre in politicised spaces of storytelling and try to collaborate with influential members/groups who can facilitate that DMOs' version of the stories remain mobile.

4 Proposed methodology

The venue of inquiry are social media platforms where a netnography will be performed on three specific online platforms (Hine, 2000; Kozinets, 2010). In addition, there will be a case study of a DMO, in this case *VisitDenmark*. As part of the netnography, specific participants are selected and their storytelling is observed in order to examine how they mediate their tourism experiences. The participants (storytellers) are selected based on the amount of content they write about Denmark. Furthermore, they should be from particular source markets so they have a common cultural background. The aim of the netnography is also to examine whether they mediate their experiences differently across platforms, as the venues might influence their storytelling practises due to their performative power. The selected online platforms are therefore *Virtual Tourist*, *TravelPod* and *Facebook*. The first two platforms are chosen because they focus on travel experiences and their content is easily accessible; many of its users are writing large amounts of content about

Denmark. *Facebook* is chosen because it may show how the performativity of platforms influence storytelling. The strategy is to contact storytellers on *Virtual Tourist* and *TravelPod* and then ask them for access to their *Facebook* profile.

The ethnographic observations and the consequent data analysis are grounded in the theoretical framework, which provides a foundation for understanding how the storytellers' performances are produced and influenced by performative spaces, mobilities and power within socialities. For instance, the act of performance is among other things analysed on the basis of how storytellers are staging themselves in their stories and images, while mobilities and power are analysed on the basis of whether the audiences share their stories and respond to them; as well as how they respond. The data is analysed with discourse analysis, which is useful for exploring the ways of constructing social reality, discourses and identities through storytelling and power structures (Phillips and Hardy, 2002). As part of the ethnography, interviews are performed with participants to ensure that the researcher are interpreting their stories accurately. The interviews are analysed using thematic analysis, which is applicable for identifying themes, patterns, and relationships in texts (Boyatzis, 1998).

As mentioned, *VisitDenmark* is chosen as a case study. The aim is to examine how DMOs are presently interacting with social media storytellers and what challenges and opportunities there are. Thus, the case study will provide a better understanding of working processes and strategies in relation to social media. *VisitDenmark* are currently putting a lot of effort into their social media strategies and have just launched a new strategy where tourist involvement in branding is a governing principle. Furthermore, approximately 10 interviews are conducted with social media managers at DMOs in Europe in order to learn more about social media practices and strategies. The interviews make the research more representative.

The research philosophy is informed by a qualitative approach, as storytellers will be studied in their natural setting (Denzin and Lincoln, 2011). The research is within a relativist ontology as the stories construct different identities and realities on different social networks. Reality only exists within people's minds and everything is open for multiple interpretations (Guba, 1990). The epistemology is therefore subjective as reality can be viewed differently depending on the person and the context. Thus, it leads to a constructivist paradigm where no objectivity is possible as it is a construction between the inquirer and the participants.

5 Anticipated results

It is expected that the case study and interviews with social media managers will show that storytellers are presently being empowered by DMOs as brand advocates in co-constructing destination narratives. Thus, DMOs are facilitating various degrees of cooperation. This research is also expected to create great value for DMOs, as the ethnography will facilitate a better understanding of how social mechanisms within social media determine how brand narratives are shared, renegotiated, fragmented, enforced and undermined by storytellers' performances across various platforms. Hence, it should enable DMOs to improve their interaction with consumers, as they will understand why some stories are appealing and mobilised while others are ignored. Furthermore, based on the knowledge gained from the case study and interviews with social media managers, the thesis will provide DMOs with recommendations on how to improve engagement with social media storytellers.

6 References

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